

Lesson 1 A puma at large



Listen then answer the question below.

Where must the puma have come from?

Pumas are large, cat-like animals found in the Americas. When reports came into the London Zoo that a wild puma had been **spotted** 45 miles south of London, they were not taken seriously. However, as the **evidence** began to **accumulate**, experts from the zoo felt **obligated** to investigate, because the descriptions given by people who claimed to have seen the puma were extremely similar.

The **hunt** for the puma began in a small village where a woman picking **blackberries** saw 'a large cat' only five yards away. It immediately ran away when she saw it, and experts confirmed that a puma will not attack



- a **person** unless it is **cornered**. The search proved difficult, because the puma was often seen in one place in the morning and in another twenty miles away in the evening. Wherever it went, it left a trail behind of dead deer and small animals like rabbits. Paw prints were seen in several places and puma fur was found clinging to bushes. Several people reported hearing 'cat-like noises' at night and a businessman on a fishing trip saw the puma in a tree. The experts were now fully convinced that the animal was a puma, but where had it come from?
- Since no pumas had been reported missing from any zoo in the country, this one must have been owned by a private collector and somehow managed to escape. The hunt went on for several weeks, but the puma was not caught. It is disturbing to think that a dangerous wild animal is still at large in the quiet countryside.

New words and expressions

puma (title) /'pu:mə/ *n.* Large, wild American cat

spot /spɑ:t/ *v.* Notice or see

evidence /'evidəns/ *n.* Proof or signs of truth

accumulate /ə'kju:mjə,leɪt/ *v.* To gather and grow

obligate /'ɑ:blɪ,geɪt/ *v.* Must do, Forced to

hunt /hʌnt/ *n.* Search for animals

blackberry /'blæk,beri/ *n.* Dark, sweet berry.

person /'pɜ:rsən/ *n.* Human

corner /'kɔ:rnər/ *v.* Trap with no escape

trail /treɪl/ *n.* Sequence of footprints or signs

print /prɪnt/ *n.* Impression left by pressing.

cling /klɪŋ/ *v.* Hold on tightly

convince /kən'vɪns/ *v.* Make someone believe

somehow /'sʌm,haʊ/ *adv.* Don't know how

disturb /dɪ'stɜ:rb/ *v.* Causing anxiety or distress

Notes

1 **at large** This means something or someone is "on the loose" or roaming free, and they haven't been caught yet.

2 **...reports came into the London Zoo that a wild puma had been spotted...** It simply introduces the specific content of the report. It connects the "report" to what the report actually says.

3 **feel obligated to do...** This gives the feeling of a strong inner push. It means you feel it is your personal duty or responsibility to do something, even if nobody is strictly forcing you

